



Eyeing encore: Ding Liren is the defending World Champion, having claimed the title in 2023 by defeating Ian Nepomniachtchi in a tense match that went to tie-breaks. LENNART OOTES/FIDE

that also included two other Indians.

Ding, however, has had a different story. After defeating Russia's Ian Nepomniachtchi to win the World Championship in Astana, Kazakhstan, he has struggled both on and off the board. He has openly stated that he has consulted a psychiatrist.

"It doesn't seem like I've been playing the way I used to," he told *The Straits Times* recently. "The assessment (about my form) is correct, and I don't know if I will ever reach that level again."

However, he added that he was feeling okay, had been playing basketball after dinner, and was trying not to stress himself too much. Ding has also said that he is the underdog against Gukesh.

That might sound strange in another context, with Ding being the

champion and far more experienced. Gukesh, too, is taking nothing for granted.

During a recent online interaction with select media, including *Sportstar*, he said he expected Ding to approach the World Championship match in the right spirit. "He will be trying his best," Gukesh said. "My approach is to treat every game with the utmost respect and energy and give it my best. But there is no additional pressure because of what people are saying (about my chances)."

One of those people, World No. 3 Hikaru Nakamura, has said Gukesh's chances at the World Championship are 80-20. World No. 1 and five-time World Champion Magnus Carlsen isn't as generous, though he also believes Gukesh has the upper hand.

"Gukesh is the significant favourite on current form, but in terms of peak chess ability, it is quite even," Carlsen said shortly after winning the Tata Steel Chess India rapid title in Kolkata. "And Gukesh was quite vulnerable in the last tournament he played."

"All that aside, if I were to make a prediction at this stage, I would go with the guy who has played by far the best chess between these two players over the last couple of years, which is Gukesh."

If Gukesh wins in Singapore, it will mark yet another great moment for Indian chess, especially in a year when the country secured twin golds at the Olympiad. He will be the second Indian to win the World Championship. Viswanathan Anand had won the first of his five world titles in 2000 in Tehran.

Twenty-four years later, another Asian city is gearing up for the first-ever all-Asian battle for the World Chess Championship. It is a 14-game match. If the score remains tied, games with shorter time controls will decide the winner.

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